



REUTERS

Modernisation has suffered because most officers handling the issue lack knowledge and field experience. The imbalance needs to be urgently addressed. The internal security division should be transformed into a body of experts capable of dealing with terrorism, insurgency and illegal infiltration.

There are other priority issues that the MHA needs to pursue. There is still no system in place which can identify and weed out illegal immigrants. Starting in 2002, attempts were made to issue Multipurpose National Identity Cards (MNIC) to all bona fide citizens with the aim of enhancing national security, manage citizen identity and facilitate e-governance. With an estimated budget of

and equipping first responders and managing a federal emergency response.

Clearly, India can learn a lot from the American review of its homeland security. Given that bureaucracy tends to create more muddles in India, perhaps the solution lies in segregating the internal security aspect from other functions of the Home Ministry. The US Homeland Security Department does not deal with issues pertaining to police modernisation, procurement and other executive work. So it would probably help if there is a full-time Cabinet Minister to look after internal security, segregated from the MHA.

In the first flush of his tenure, Chidambaram has moved swiftly to get a National Investigative Agency set up to investigate terror cases across the country and also ensured greater co-ordination and sharing of information among intelligence agencies by reactivating the Multi-Agency Centre (MAC)

and making it accountable. The focus now has to be firmly on prevention through enhanced intelligence coordination and sharing. He has also cut through the red tape and sanctioned long pending and much-needed equipment for the paramilitary forces like bullet-proof vests and rifles.

These would make a significant difference. But as important is pushing for fundamental structural and personnel changes in the Home Ministry. It could start by looking at the composition of those who head it. Of the eight special and additional secretaries in the Ministry, and 20 joint secretaries, only two are career police officers. Starting from secretary Madhukar Gupta, almost all in key positions are IAS officers with no experience of handling security issues. All officials handling key desks, including Kashmir, the Northeast, Naxals and Border Management are administrative service officers.

## Experts' Opinion

Former top police officials and intelligence experts want an overhaul in the country's security

**G.C. SAXENA**



Former  
R&AW  
chief

**K. SUBRAHMANYAM**



Security  
expert

**GOPAL SHARMA**



Former  
DGP  
J&K

■ Single counter-terrorism centre that deals with intelligence gathering, dissemination & coordination

■ Well trained and equipped QRTs at vital installations

■ A full time cabinet minister to look after internal security

■ A dedicated cadre of officers, specialists in national security in MHA

■ A national ID card for all Indian nationals within six months

■ Bring in meritocracy, specialisation and enhance the Special Task Forces